

CER-02 · CERTIFICATION HANDBOOK

The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI

Three credentials, one standard, and one honest difference
between them

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

PCI certifies three credentials at Leader level — PCL-AI in project controls, PFL-AI in project finance and PML-AI in project management — each valid for three years and each built on the same governed-AI principle. This document explains what distinguishes them, which competencies each one claims, how to choose between them, and the one difference that matters most before you pay: only PCL-AI has a published examination blueprint. PFL-AI and PML-AI have none yet.

— About this document

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Contents

1. Start with the difference that decides it.....	4
2. The three credentials	4
2.1 The register	4
2.2 PCL-AI — PCI AI Project Controls Leader	5
2.3 PFL-AI — PCI AI Project Finance Leader	5
2.4 PML-AI — PCI Project Management Leader - AI.....	5
2.5 The competency counts are not a ranking	5
3. What all three share	6
3.1 The governing principle	6
3.2 Common delivery settings	6
3.3 One maintenance regime	6
4. The fourth offering, which is not one of the three	6
5. Choosing between them	7
5.1 Choose on accountability, not on job title	7
5.2 Choose on the evidence available today	7
5.3 You are not choosing for ever	7
6. How this goes wrong	7
Related	8
Sources and standards.....	8
Status and version	8

The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI

In one paragraph. PCI certifies three credentials at Leader level — PCL-AI in project controls, PFL-AI in project finance and PML-AI in project management — each valid for three years and each built on the same governed-AI principle. This document explains what distinguishes them, which competencies each one claims, how to choose between them, and the one difference that matters most before you pay: only PCL-AI has a published examination blueprint. PFL-AI and PML-AI have none yet.

Who this is for. Practitioners deciding which credential to sit; managers and employers deciding which credential to sponsor; anyone who has seen the three codes and cannot tell from the marketing which one describes their job.

— 1. Start with the difference that decides it

Before anything else about scope, level or audience: **only PCL-AI has a published examination blueprint.** The blueprint is the document that tells you what will be assessed and in what proportion — the domain map and the weightings. For PCL-AI it exists and is published as [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#). For **PFL-AI and PML-AI there is no published blueprint: no domain weightings and no item counts.**

Both statements matter to a candidate in a practical way:

1. If you want to see precisely what you will be assessed on before you commit money and study time, PCL-AI is the credential where that information exists today.
2. The absence of a blueprint for the other two is not a gap in this document. It is a gap in the scheme, and the Institute publishes it as such rather than implying coverage it does not have.

What each of the three does have today is a **defined competency set**, seeded in the platform and explained in the S03 series. A competency set says what the credential claims about a holder. A blueprint says how an examination samples it. They are not the same instrument and one does not substitute for the other.

— 2. The three credentials

2.1 The register

Code	Full name	Display	Category	Post-nominal	Validity
PCL-AI	PCI AI Project Controls Leader	PCI PCL-AI	Project controls	PCL-AI	3 years
PFL-AI	PCI AI Project Finance Leader	PCI PFL-AI	Project finance	PFL-AI	3 years
PML-AI	PCI Project Management Leader – AI	PCI PML-AI	Project management	PML-AI	3 years

Together they are the **PCI AI Project Leadership Certification Suite**. All three sit at **Leader** level: the credential addresses the person who owns the integrity of the numbers and the decisions taken from them, not the person who assembles them for someone else to own.

2.2 PCL-AI — PCI AI Project Controls Leader

PCL-AI certifies the integrated controls discipline: the ability to plan, measure, forecast, control and finance a project, and to apply AI to that work responsibly. Its **fourteen competencies** are project controls governance; cost management; planning and scheduling; earned value management; forecasting and estimate at completion; performance measurement; project risk; commercial and contract controls; predictive analytics; AI-enabled project controls; digital reporting; automation; responsible AI; and human validation.

Recognise yourself here if your working week is spent holding a project to account: cost engineers and cost controllers, planners and schedulers, project controls engineers and managers, PMO professionals.

2.3 PFL-AI — PCI AI Project Finance Leader

PFL-AI certifies the finance side of the same discipline: whether a project can be financed, on what terms, and whether the model that says so can be defended. Its **nineteen competencies** are project finance; infrastructure finance; financial modelling; investment appraisal; capital structure; debt and equity; project bankability; the debt-service, loan-life and project-life coverage ratios; public-private partnerships and concessions; project contracts; financial close; commercial and financial risk; sustainable finance; Islamic project finance; AI-enabled financial modelling; predictive cash-flow analysis; digital due diligence; responsible AI; and human validation.

Recognise yourself here if you build, challenge or rely on the model that decides whether a project proceeds: project finance analysts and managers, infrastructure and capital-markets professionals, commercial and investment leads, and controls professionals whose work terminates in a funding decision.

2.4 PML-AI — PCI Project Management Leader - AI

PML-AI certifies delivery leadership with controls literacy and governed AI built in. Its **twenty-four competencies** are project management; project leadership; project initiation; business cases; governance; scope and requirements; planning and execution; stakeholder leadership; procurement; contracts and commercial delivery; cost, schedule and risk integration; predictive delivery; agile delivery; hybrid delivery; quality and change management; benefits realisation; sustainability; project closure; AI-enabled project management; decision intelligence; digital delivery; automation; responsible AI; and human accountability.

Recognise yourself here if you are accountable for the outcome rather than for a control function within it: project, programme and portfolio managers, delivery leads, and controls professionals moving into delivery accountability.

2.5 The competency counts are not a ranking

Fourteen, nineteen and twenty-four are the sizes of three differently shaped domains, not a hierarchy of difficulty. PFL-AI carries more competencies than PCL-AI because project finance decomposes into more distinct instruments, not because it is harder or worth more. Nothing in the suite makes one credential senior to another; all three are Leader level.

— 3. What all three share

3.1 The governing principle

AI proposes; the professional disposes. Across all three credentials, AI may draft, calculate, summarise, detect and forecast — and a competent human validates, explains and owns every conclusion that carries a professional's name. Every competency set ends on the same two entries for this reason: **responsible AI**, and **human validation** or **human accountability**. That is not decoration. It is the claim the credential makes about its holder.

3.2 Common delivery settings

The Institute configures delivery once and applies it across the suite, with the ability to override a setting for an individual certification where the assessment genuinely requires it. The common settings today are a **90-minute** sitting, **four-option multiple-choice items with a single best answer**, **criterion-referenced** scoring, **no formula sheet** provided, an **immediate result with a domain breakdown**, seven interface languages, and **three-year** validity.

Two figures are deliberately not settled and are stated the same way for every credential in the suite: **no item count exists**, and it will be confirmed by a formal job-task analysis; and the **65 %** pass mark configured in the platform is not yet the definitive standard, which will be set by a modified-Angoff standard-setting study. [CER-01](#) §8 and [EXB-05](#) carry the detail.

3.3 One maintenance regime

All three are maintained the same way: a three-year cycle of continuing professional development with a mandatory AI-currency component. A credential holder in project finance and a credential holder in controls face the same obligation to stay current with a technology that is changing both. See [CER-08](#).

— 4. The fourth offering, which is not one of the three

The **AI in Project Controls — Specialist Certificate (AIPC)** is a certificate, not a credential in the suite. It is **open entry with no prerequisite**, drawn from Domain 13 of the PCL-AI Body of Knowledge, and assessed by scenario items plus an applied AI task rather than by the suite's examination format.

It is the right instrument if you want a governed grounding in AI for controls work without committing to a Leader-level credential — and the wrong one if what you need is the credential. It does not carry a post-nominal in the suite, is not a step on a certification ladder that ends in PCL-AI, and does not satisfy any part of the suite's requirements.

— 5. Choosing between them

5.1 Choose on accountability, not on job title

Job titles are unreliable across sectors and countries; the same title means three different jobs in three different companies. Choose instead on the question you are most often the last person to answer:

The question you own	The credential
Is this forecast defensible, and what does the data actually support?	PCL-AI
Can this be financed, on what terms, and does the model survive challenge?	PFL-AI
Should we proceed, and can we deliver what we have committed to?	PML-AI

If two of those describe you, take the one that describes the decision your name appears against.

5.2 Choose on the evidence available today

If your decision depends on knowing exactly what will be assessed — because you are budgeting study time, building a corporate training plan, or answering to someone who will ask — PCL-AI is the credential with a published blueprint. That is a statement about publication status, not about quality.

5.3 You are not choosing for ever

Credentials in the suite are separate awards, not levels of one award. Holding one does not exempt you from another's assessment, and holding one does not preclude the others. There is no order in which they must be taken.

— 6. How this goes wrong

- **Treating the suite as a ladder.** Candidates assume PCL-AI is the entry credential and PML-AI the senior one, then plan a multi-year sequence that does not exist. Three parallel awards, one level.
- **Choosing PFL-AI or PML-AI expecting a published blueprint.** Read §1 again before you pay. The competency set is published; the examination blueprint is not.
- **Mistaking the specialist certificate for a credential.** AIPC is open entry and does not certify Leader-level competence in anything. It is a good first step and a poor substitute.
- **Confusing a credential with a membership grade.** SPCI, APCI, MPCl and FPCI are membership standings on a separate ladder. A credential is earned by examination. CER-01 §2.3.
- **Reading the competency count as a difficulty rating.** See §2.5.
- **Assuming the AI content is a separate module you can skip.** AI is examined throughout the framework and carries 20 % in its own right in the PCL-AI blueprint. It is not an appendix.

— Related

- [CER-01 – Certification handbook – master](#) — the whole candidate journey, of which this is the first decision
- [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#) — the published blueprint referred to throughout §1
- [CMP-03 – PCL-AI: the fourteen competencies](#) — what each PCL-AI competency means and how it is evidenced
- [CMP-04 – PFL-AI: the nineteen competencies](#) — the same treatment for project finance
- [CMP-05 – PML-AI: the twenty-four competencies](#) — the same treatment for delivery leadership
- [CER-04 – Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary](#) — how you enter, once you have chosen

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform certification records and seeded competency sets, verified August 2026 — the source of the fourteen, nineteen and twenty-four competencies quoted in §2.
- PCI Publication Framework, [CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §§1, 3, 7 and 9, August 2026.
- Note on a known inconsistency: the platform database records all three credentials at **Leader** level while one public page currently renders "Level: Professional". Leader is correct, and the word professional elsewhere in the framework refers to a competency scale, not to this credential level.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 — effective date to be confirmed · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.